

Kota Kinabalu Travel Guide

27 Must-Visit Locations for First-Time Visitors

Starting Point: Gayang Friendly Water House

Locations List

1. Mount Kinabalu
2. Tunku Abdul Rahman Marine Park
3. KK Wetland Centre
4. Tanjung Aru Beach
5. Lok Kawi Wildlife Park
6. Klias Wetlands
7. Kiulu River
8. Crocker Range Park
9. Signal Hill
10. Poring Hot Springs
11. Mengalum Island
12. Mantanani Islands
13. Kokol Hill
14. Pulau Tiga (Survivor Island)
15. Pantai Dalit Nature Reserve
16. Gayang Friendly Water House
17. Kota Kinabalu City Center
18. Upside Down House (Rumah Terbalik)
19. Borneo Ant House
20. Tamparuli Suspension Bridge
21. Chanteek Borneo Indigenous Museum
22. Kundasang War Memorial
23. Desa Dairy Farm
24. Monsopiad Cultural Village
25. St. Michael's Church (Penampang)

26. Kokol Hill Elf

27. Tuaran Town (Local Market)

1. Mount Kinabalu

Ø=P— 78 km • 1h 40m from Gayang

The majestic centerpiece of Sabah. A UNESCO World Heritage site known for its unique flora and fauna, ranging from lowland rainforest to alpine meadows.

Highlights:

- Endemic Orchids
- Nepenthes (Pitcher Plants)
- Granite Peaks

2. Tunku Abdul Rahman Marine Park

Ø=P— 28 km • 40m (to Jetty) from Gayang

A sanctuary of five islands with vibrant coral reefs. Accessed via Jesselton Point Ferry Terminal.

Highlights:

- Coral Reefs
- Sea Turtles
- Tropical Fish

3. KK Wetland Centre

Ø=P— 26 km • 35m from Gayang

A crucial mangrove ecosystem in the heart of the city. It serves as a feeding ground for migratory birds.

Highlights:

- Mangrove Boardwalk
- Bird Watching
- Mudskippers & Crabs

4. Tanjung Aru Beach

Ø=P— 34 km • 50m from Gayang

A beautiful stretch of white sand and Casuarina trees, famous for its ecosystem that supports iconic Bornean sunsets.

Highlights:

- Casuarina Trees
- Coastal Ecosystem
- Stunning Sunsets

5. Lok Kawi Wildlife Park

Ø=Þ— 42 km • 1h 0m from Gayang

A combination of a zoo and a botanical garden, focusing on the preservation and exhibition of Borneo's unique wildlife.

Highlights:

- Proboscis Monkeys
- Bornean Pygmy Elephants
- Orangutans

6. Klias Wetlands

Ø=Þ— 135 km • 2h 40m from Gayang

A riverine forest system located south of KK, famous for its population of proboscis monkeys and fireflies.

Highlights:

- Proboscis Monkeys
- Firefly Cruises
- River Ecosystem

7. Kiulu River

Ø=Þ— 22 km • 35m from Gayang

A gentle river winding through lush valleys, offering a scenic nature experience and light white-water rafting.

Highlights:

- River Rafting
- Green Valleys
- Freshwater Ecology

8. Crocker Range Park

Ø=Þ— 85 km • 2h 10m from Gayang

Sabah's largest terrestrial park, protecting the mountainous backbone of the West Coast.

Highlights:

- Rafflesia Monitoring
- Cloud Forests
- Jungle Trekking

9. Signal Hill

Ø=P— 29 km • 45m from Gayang

The closest natural forest reserve to the city center, providing a green lung and habitat for small birds and mammals.

Highlights:

- Primary Forest Patch
- City Green Lung
- Nature Trails

10. Poring Hot Springs

Ø=P— 115 km • 2h 30m from Gayang

Nestled in the rainforest near Mount Kinabalu, featuring therapeutic hot springs and a canopy walk.

Highlights:

- Canopy Walk
- Rafflesia Flowers
- Natural Hot Springs

11. Mengalum Island

Ø=P— 28 km • 40m (to Jetty) from Gayang

An offshore paradise known for its pristine white beaches and deep-sea coral systems.

Highlights:

- Deep Sea Snorkeling
- Pristine Beaches
- Marine Conservation

12. Mantanani Islands

Ø=P— 35 km • 45m (to Rampayan Jetty) from Gayang

Known as the 'Mermaid Islands', these remote gems offer crystal clear waters and are a habitat for the rare Dugong.

Highlights:

- Dugong Sightings
- Crystal Clear Water
- Diving

13. Kokol Hill

Ø=P— 18 km • 30m from Gayang

A highland area offering cooler temperatures and a different ecological zone compared to the coastal plains.

Highlights:

- Highland Flora
- Cool Climate
- Panoramic Nature Views

14. Pulau Tiga (Survivor Island)

Ø=P— 145 km • 2h 50m (to Kuala Penyu Jetty) from Gayang

Famous for its volcanic mud baths and diverse wildlife, including megapodes and sea snakes.

Highlights:

- Volcanic Mud Baths
- Snake Island
- Wildlife Trekking

15. Pantai Dalit Nature Reserve

Ø=P— 4 km • 8m from Gayang

A managed forest reserve that protects indigenous flora and provides a sanctuary for rehabilitated wildlife.

Highlights:

- Forest Restoration
- Orchid Garden
- Eco-friendly Trails

16. Gayang Friendly Water House

Ø=P— 0 km • You are here from Gayang

Your starting point. A unique water village community and seafood destination built on stilts over the Gayang river estuary.

Highlights:

- Stilt House Architecture
- Fresh Seafood
- Estuary Views

17. Kota Kinabalu City Center

Ø=Þ— 28 km • 45m from Gayang

The vibrant heart of Sabah. A mix of modern shopping malls, colonial history, and a bustling waterfront with stunning sunset views.

Highlights:

- Waterfront Esplanade
- Shopping & Dining
- Historical Landmarks

18. Upside Down House (Rumah Terbalik)

Ø=Þ— 8 km • 12m from Gayang

The first upside-down house in Southeast Asia. This traditional Sabah-style house is built entirely upside down, including the interior furniture and appliances.

Highlights:

- Optical Illusions
- Traditional Architecture
- 3D Wonders Museum

19. Borneo Ant House

Ø=Þ— 4 km • 8m from Gayang

An underground theme park and museum that focuses on the culture of the local Bajau and Dusun people, as well as unique insect displays.

Highlights:

- Underground Galleries
- Bajau Culture
- Canopy Walk

20. Tamparuli Suspension Bridge

Ø=Þ— 10 km • 15m from Gayang

An iconic suspension bridge made famous by a local folk song. It spans across the Tuaran River and offers a charming small-town experience.

Highlights:

- Historic Bridge
- Small Town Vibes
- Jambatan Tamparuli song history

21. Chanteek Borneo Indigenous Museum

Ø=Þ— 11 km • 16m from Gayang

A cultural museum showcasing miniature dioramas and dolls dressed in the traditional costumes of Sabah's 40+ ethnic groups.

Highlights:

- Miniature Costumes
- Ethnic Diversity
- Cultural Education

22. Kundasang War Memorial

Ø=Þ— 75 km • 1h 35m from Gayang

A beautiful memorial park dedicated to the British and Australian soldiers who died in the Sandakan POW camps during WWII.

Highlights:

- Historic Memorial
- Beautiful Gardens
- World War II History

23. Desa Dairy Farm

Ø=Þ— 73 km • 1h 30m from Gayang

Often called the 'New Zealand of Sabah,' this high-altitude dairy farm offers stunning views of Mount Kinabalu and fresh dairy products.

Highlights:

- Cow Feeding
- Fresh Milk & Gelato
- Mountain Views

24. Monsopiad Cultural Village

Ø=Þ— 45 km • 1h 0m from Gayang

A living museum dedicated to the Kadazan-Dusun warrior Monsopiad. It houses the infamous 'House of Skulls.'

Highlights:

- House of Skulls
- Kadazan Heritage
- Warrior Demonstrations

25. St. Michael's Church (Penampang)

Ø=↳— 38 km • 50m from Gayang

One of the oldest stone churches in Sabah, built in the early 20th century. It sits on a hill overlooking the Penampang district.

Highlights:

- Stone Architecture
- Colonial History
- Peaceful Surroundings

26. Kokol Hill Elf

Ø=↳— 18 km • 30m from Gayang

A commercialized observation area on Kokol Hill with swings, photo-ops, and a café, designed specifically for tourists and photographers.

Highlights:

- Giant Swing
- Instagrammable Spots
- Sunset Views

27. Tuaran Town (Local Market)

Ø=↳— 6 km • 10m from Gayang

A bustling local town center famous for its 'Mee Tuaran' (local noodles) and the weekly 'Tamu' (market) where villagers sell fresh produce.

Highlights:

- Mee Tuaran
- Local Market (Tamu)
- Nine-Story Pagoda